The `config` directory contains files that configure Rails. In the process of developing Depot, we configured a few routes, configured the database, created an initializer, modified some locales, and defined deployment instructions. The rest of the configuration was done via Rails conventions.

Before running your application, Rails loads and executes `config/environment.rb` and `config/application.rb`. The standard environment set up automatically by these files includes the following directories (relative to your application's base directory) in your application's load path:

- The `app/controllers` directory and its subdirectories
- The `app/models` directory
- The `vendor` directory and the `lib` contained in each `plugin` subdirectory
- The directories `app`, `app/helpers`, `app/mailers`, and `app/*/concerns`

Each of these directories is added to the load path only if it exists.

In addition, Rails will load a per-environment configuration file. This file lives in the `environments` directory and is where you place configuration options that vary depending on the environment.

This is done because Rails recognizes that your needs, as a developer, are very different when writing code, testing code, and running that code in production. When writing code, you want lots of logging, convenient reloading of changed source files, in-your-face notification of errors, and so on. In testing, you want a system that exists in isolation so you can have repeatable results. In production, your system should be tuned for performance, and users should be kept away from errors.

The switch that dictates the runtime environment is external to your application. This means that no application code needs to be changed as you move from development through testing to production. When starting a server with the `bin/rails server` command, we use the `-e` option:

```
depot> bin/rails server -e development
```